JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category : Cyber Safety & Digital Security

MODULE 1: Introduction to Cyber Security

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Cyber Security** — what it is, why every Indian citizen needs to understand it, and the many forms of cyber threats active in India today. Whether you are a student, a working professional, a parent, or a senior citizen taking your first steps online, this handbook is written so that you can read it once and walk away confident, informed, and safer.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to understand the fundamentals of cyber security.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Define cyber security in simple, practical terms
- Explain why cyber security matters to individuals, businesses, and the nation
- Identify the major categories and real-world types of cyber threats
- Recognise common cyberattack patterns used against Indian citizens
- Understand the government bodies and laws that protect Indian internet users
- Apply basic safety practices immediately in daily digital life
- Distinguish between common cyber security myths and facts
- Know exactly where and how to report a cybercrime in India

Why This Topic Matters

India is one of the largest and fastest-growing digital economies in the world. UPI payments, Aadhaar-linked services, online banking, e-commerce, and social media have become part of everyday life for hundreds of millions of citizens. This convenience, however, comes with risk.

> *Reality Check: Cybercrime complaints in India rose sharply in recent years, with financial losses running into thousands of crores of rupees annually. A large share of these losses come from ordinary citizens being tricked through phone calls, fake messages, and fraudulent apps — not through complex hacking.*

Cyber security is no longer a topic only for IT professionals. It is a **life skill**, similar to knowing how to cross a road safely or lock your front door. A single moment of carelessness — clicking one link, sharing one OTP, trusting one caller — can lead to financial loss, identity theft, or emotional harm.

This is why JanGyan begins its Cyber Safety category with this foundational module.

Introduction

Cyber Security refers to the practice of protecting computers, mobile phones, servers, networks, applications, and data from digital attacks, unauthorised access, damage, or theft.

In simple words: cyber security is the digital version of the locks, guards, and alarms we use to protect our homes — except here, we are protecting our devices, our money, our identity, and our personal information.

Cyber security is not a single tool or a single action. It is a **combination of people, processes, and technology** working together:

Element	Role
People	Awareness, safe habits, common sense
Process	Rules, policies, verification steps
Technology	Antivirus, firewalls, encryption, authentication

A strong lock on your door is useless if you leave the door open. Similarly, the best antivirus software cannot protect you if you willingly share your OTP with a fraudster. This is why **awareness is the first and most powerful layer of cyber security.**

Fundamental Concepts

Before going deeper, let us understand a few foundational ideas that the entire subject of cyber security is built upon.

The CIA Triad

Cyber security professionals worldwide build their strategies around three core principles, known as the **CIA Triad**:

Principle	Meaning	Simple Example
Confidentiality	Only authorised people can access information	Your bank OTP should be seen only by you
Integrity	Information must remain accurate and unaltered	Your account balance should not be secretly changed
Availability	Systems and data must be accessible when needed	Your UPI app should work when you need to pay

Key Definitions

- **Asset** — Anything of value that needs protection (a phone, a bank account, personal photos, business data).
- **Threat** — Any potential danger that could exploit a weakness (a hacker, a virus, a scam call).
- **Vulnerability** — A weakness that a threat can take advantage of (an outdated app, a weak password).
- **Risk** — The possibility of loss or damage when a threat exploits a vulnerability.
- **Attack Surface** — The total number of points where an unauthorised person could try to gain access (your email, social media, banking apps, Wi-Fi router, etc.).

Example: An outdated banking app (vulnerability) combined with a fraudster sending a fake update link (threat) creates a risk of your account being compromised (attack).

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — What Is Cyber Security, In Depth

Cyber security covers the protection of:

- **Devices** — smartphones, laptops, tablets, smart TVs, IoT devices
- **Networks** — home Wi-Fi, mobile data, office networks
- **Applications** — banking apps, social media, e-commerce platforms
- **Data** — personal information, financial records, photos, documents
- **Identity** — Aadhaar number, PAN, passwords, biometric data

Cyber security operates at multiple levels simultaneously — an individual securing their own phone, a company securing its servers, and a government securing national digital infrastructure such as power grids, banking systems, and defence networks.

Part B — Types of Cyber Threats (Detailed)

This is the heart of the module. Cyber threats can be grouped into broad categories. Below, each is explained with a definition, how it works, and its relevance in India.

1. Malware (Malicious Software)

Definition: Malware is any software specifically designed to damage, disrupt, or gain unauthorised access to a device or network.

Type	How It Works
Virus	Attaches itself to a legitimate file and spreads when the file is shared or opened
Worm	Spreads automatically across networks without needing a host file
Trojan Horse	Disguises itself as legitimate software (e.g., a fake "APK update") to trick users into installing it
Spyware	Secretly monitors activity, keystrokes, and messages
Ransomware	Locks or encrypts files/systems and demands payment to restore access
Adware	Floods the device with unwanted advertisements, often bundled with spyware

In India, fake APK files shared via WhatsApp (disguised as courier tracking apps, government forms, or "electricity bill" apps) are a growing trojan-based threat, especially targeting first-time smartphone users.

2. Phishing, Vishing & Smishing

Phishing is the practice of tricking someone into revealing sensitive information (passwords, OTPs, card details) by pretending to be a trustworthy entity.

- **Phishing** — via fraudulent emails or fake websites that mimic real banks or companies

- **Vishing** — voice phishing, done through fraudulent phone calls (e.g., fake bank officials, fake "customs officer" calls)
- **Smishing** — SMS-based phishing (e.g., fake "your account will be blocked" or "KYC update" text messages with malicious links)

3. Social Engineering

Social engineering is the psychological manipulation of people into breaking normal security procedures. Unlike technical hacking, this exploits **human trust, fear, greed, or urgency** rather than software weaknesses. Almost every cyber fraud in India today involves some form of social engineering.

4. Identity Theft

The unauthorised use of someone's personal information (Aadhaar number, PAN, bank details) to commit fraud, open accounts, or impersonate the victim — increasingly common with data leaks and careless sharing of KYC documents.

5. Financial & UPI Fraud

India's rapid adoption of UPI and digital payments has created a specific category of frauds:

- Fake payment request links disguised as "receiving" money
- QR code scams where scanning actually authorises a payment out of the account
- Fake customer care numbers found through unofficial Google searches
- Loan app frauds and fake investment/trading platforms

6. "Digital Arrest" Scams

A newer and rapidly growing threat in India, where fraudsters impersonate police officers, CBI officials, or customs officers over video calls, falsely claiming the victim is under investigation (often related to a fake parcel, money laundering allegation, or SIM card misuse), and pressure the victim into transferring money or staying on a video call ("digital arrest") out of fear, to avoid genuine arrest. **No Indian law enforcement agency arrests, investigates, or collects fines via video call.**

7. Deepfake & AI Voice-Cloning Scams

With the growth of generative AI, fraudsters now use cloned voices or manipulated videos of family members, celebrities, or officials to create panic (e.g., a fake "emergency" call from a cloned voice of a relative asking for urgent money transfer).

8. Sextortion & Emotional Manipulation Scams

Scammers build fake romantic or friendly relationships online (often via social media or matrimonial platforms), then use compromising images/videos or emotional manipulation to extort money.

9. Man-in-the-Middle (MITM) Attacks

An attacker secretly intercepts communication between two parties (e.g., over unsecured public Wi-Fi) to steal data or alter messages without either party knowing.

10. Denial-of-Service (DoS/DDoS) Attacks

Attackers flood a website or server with excessive traffic, making it unavailable to genuine users — commonly used against businesses, banks, and government portals.

11. Data Breaches

Large-scale unauthorised access to stored data (customer records, passwords, financial details) held by companies or organisations, often later sold or misused on the dark web.

12. IoT (Internet of Things) Threats

Smart devices — CCTV cameras, smart TVs, smart locks — often ship with weak default passwords, making them easy targets for attackers to access home networks.

13. Cyberbullying & Online Harassment

The use of digital platforms to threaten, humiliate, or harass another person — a particularly serious concern for students and children, and a category the Government of India treats with special sensitivity and dedicated reporting channels.

14. Job & Task Fraud

Fake work-from-home job offers, "like and earn" task scams, and fraudulent recruitment messages that ask victims to pay a "registration fee" or share banking details upfront.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Firewall	A digital gatekeeper that filters incoming/outgoing network traffic
Antivirus	Software that detects and removes malicious programs
Encryption	Converting data into unreadable code so only authorised parties can read it
Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)	An extra verification step beyond a password (e.g., OTP)
VPN	A tool that creates a secure, private connection over the internet
Patch/Update	A software fix released to close security gaps
Phishing Link	A fraudulent link designed to steal information
OTP	One-Time Password used to verify a transaction or login
Cyber Hygiene	Regular safe habits that keep devices and accounts secure
Zero-Day Vulnerability	A security flaw unknown to the software maker, exploited before a fix exists

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Step-by-Step Understanding

How a Typical Cyber Fraud Unfolds

1. **Contact** — Victim receives a call, SMS, email, or social media message
2. **Trust-Building** — Fraudster poses as a bank, government official, delivery agent, or relative
3. **Urgency or Fear** — A false emergency is created ("your account will be blocked today", "you are under investigation")
4. **Information/Access Request** — Victim is asked for OTP, remote access app, or to click a link
5. **Exploitation** — Money is transferred, or credentials are stolen

6. **Disappearance** — Fraudster becomes unreachable

How to Build Your Personal Cyber Security (Step-by-Step)

1. Secure your devices with strong screen locks and updated software
2. Use strong, unique passwords with a password manager
3. Enable Two-Factor Authentication wherever available
4. Verify before you trust — official numbers, official apps, official websites only
5. Never share OTP, PIN, or CVV with anyone, ever
6. Back up important data regularly
7. Report suspicious activity immediately via official channels

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Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely reported public incidents, described for educational awareness — not to be reproduced as legal fact.)

- **Cosmos Bank Cyber Heist (Pune, 2018):** Attackers used malware to compromise the bank's payment switch system, enabling fraudulent transactions worth a large sum within hours — a well-known case study in critical infrastructure attacks on Indian banking systems.
- **WannaCry Ransomware (2017):** A global ransomware attack that also affected some computer systems in India, encrypting files and demanding ransom — highlighting the importance of timely software updates.
- **Hospital Ransomware Disruption (Delhi, 2022):** A major public hospital's digital systems were disrupted for an extended period following a ransomware attack, delaying patient services — a stark reminder that critical public services are also targets.
- **Rise of "Digital Arrest" Cases (2023–2025):** Numerous cases were reported across Indian cities where citizens, including educated professionals and senior citizens, were coerced into transferring large sums after being falsely told they were under investigation via video call.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: You get a call saying a parcel in your name contains illegal items and you must "verify your identity" on a video call with a "customs officer."

This is a digital arrest scam. Disconnect immediately and report via 1930.

Scenario 2: You receive a message that your electricity connection will be disconnected tonight unless you click a link and pay immediately.

This is smishing. Verify only through your official electricity board app or website.

Scenario 3: Someone on a matrimonial or social app you've never met asks you to install an "investment app" that shows fast returns.

This is a classic investment/romance fraud pattern. Never install unknown apps or invest based on online-only relationships.

Scenario 4: Your child receives repeated messages from a stranger asking for photos.

This is a grooming/cyberbullying risk. Report immediately through the platform and to a trusted adult; use official child-safety reporting channels.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **CERT-In (Indian Computer Emergency Response Team):** India's national nodal agency for cyber incident response, functioning under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY). It collects and analyses information on cyber incidents, issues early warnings and advisories, and coordinates emergency response — including dedicated support for the financial sector (CSIRT-Fin) and power sector (CSIRT-Power).
- **I4C (Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre):** Operates under the Ministry of Home Affairs to coordinate cybercrime response nationally between states, banks, and financial institutions, including a registry that helps banks flag suspected fraudulent accounts.
- **RBI Guidelines:** The Reserve Bank of India issues periodic guidelines to banks on secure digital banking practices, fraud monitoring, and customer protection for online and UPI transactions.
- **NCIIPC:** The National Critical Information Infrastructure Protection Centre safeguards critical sectors such as power, banking, and telecom from cyberattacks.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
IT Act, 2000 — Section 43	Civil liability for unauthorised access, data damage, or hacking
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66	Criminal punishment for hacking/computer-related offences
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66C	Identity theft (misuse of password, unique ID, or digital signature)
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66D	Cheating by impersonation using a computer resource
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66E	Violation of privacy (capturing/publishing private images without consent)
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66F	Cyber terrorism
IT Act, 2000 — Sections 67, 67A, 67B	Publishing/transmitting obscene material, including material involving children
Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (DPDP Act)	India's comprehensive personal data protection law; its Rules were notified in November 2025 and are being rolled out in phases, giving citizens rights over how their personal data is collected and used, with significant penalties for violations by organisations
Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023	Now applies alongside the IT Act for offences such as cheating and impersonation committed using digital means

CERT-In is formally designated under **Section 70B** of the IT Act, 2000, as India's national cyber security agency.

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
Cybercrime cases reported in India in 2024	Approximately 22.7 lakh (2.27 million)
Cybercrime cases reported in India in 2025	Approximately 28.1 lakh (2.81 million) — a rise of roughly 24%
Reported financial loss to cyber fraud (2024)	Approximately ₹22,845 crore
Reported financial loss to cyber fraud (2025)	Approximately ₹22,495 crore
Share of 2025 losses from investment-scam fraud	More than 75%
Share of 2025 losses from "digital arrest" scams	Around 9%
Calls received on the 1930 cybercrime helpline (2025)	Over 32 million
Dedicated cyber police stations in India	459 (up from 169 in 2020)

(Figures are approximate, sourced from Ministry of Home Affairs / I4C data as reported in 2025–2026; official portals should be checked for the latest updates.)

Best Practices

- Use strong, unique passwords (12+ characters, mix of letters/numbers/symbols)
- Turn on Two-Factor Authentication for banking, email, and social media
- Update your phone, apps, and antivirus software regularly
- Download apps only from official app stores
- Verify customer care numbers only from official websites, never from Google search results or SMS
- Think before you click — hover over/preview links before opening
- Back up important files regularly, both locally and on trusted cloud storage
- Use a screen lock and enable "Find My Device" features

Common Mistakes

- Sharing OTP or PIN with anyone, even someone claiming to be "bank staff"
- Clicking links in unexpected SMS or WhatsApp messages
- Using the same password across multiple accounts
- Installing APK files sent directly via WhatsApp instead of through official app stores
- Trusting caller ID alone, which can be spoofed
- Ignoring software update notifications

• Oversharing personal details (DOB, address, travel plans) publicly on social media

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Only big companies get hacked"	Individuals are targeted far more often, since they are usually less protected
"Antivirus software alone keeps me 100% safe"	Human awareness and safe habits matter just as much as software
"The police can arrest me over a video call"	No Indian law enforcement agency conducts arrests or investigations via video call — this is always a scam
"If the caller knows my name and address, they must be genuine"	Personal details are widely available through data leaks and are used to make scams sound convincing
"Sharing an OTP just once for verification is safe"	An OTP should never be shared under any circumstance — it directly authorises a transaction
"Cybercrime only happens through hacking skills"	Most frauds succeed through psychological manipulation, not technical hacking

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Verify unknown calls independently through official numbers	Don't act immediately out of fear or urgency
Report suspicious activity to 1930 or cybercrime.gov.in	Don't try to "handle it yourself" by negotiating with scammers
Enable app-lock and device encryption	Don't leave your phone unlocked or lend it carelessly
Teach children and elderly family members basic cyber safety	Don't assume older or younger family members already know the risks
Keep software updated	Don't ignore update notifications for "later"

Safety Tips

For Banking & Payments

- Never share OTP, PIN, CVV, or UPI PIN with anyone
- Set transaction limits on UPI apps
- Check your bank statement regularly for unfamiliar transactions

For Social Media
- Keep personal profiles private
- Avoid sharing live location or travel plans publicly
- Be cautious of unknown friend/connection requests

For Families & Children
- Use parental control settings on devices
- Encourage open conversation about anything uncomfortable seen online
- Teach children to never share personal photos or information with strangers

For Senior Citizens
- Be extra cautious of calls claiming to be from "bank," "government," or "courier" services
- Involve a trusted family member before making any online payment based on a phone call
- Remember: genuine government agencies never ask for money over video/phone calls

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Practical Checklist

- ☐ Strong, unique password set for every important account
- ☐ Two-Factor Authentication enabled on email and banking apps
- ☐ Phone and apps updated to the latest version
- ☐ Antivirus/security app installed on devices
- ☐ Screen lock and biometric lock enabled
- ☐ Important documents/photos backed up securely
- ☐ Bank and UPI transaction alerts turned on
- ☐ Saved the 1930 cybercrime helpline number in your phone
- ☐ Discussed basic cyber safety with family members/children

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Quick Revision Notes

- Cyber security = protecting devices, networks, data, and identity from digital threats
- CIA Triad = Confidentiality, Integrity, Availability
- Major threats: malware, phishing/vishing/smishing, social engineering, identity theft, UPI fraud, digital arrest scams, deepfake scams, MITM, DDoS, data breaches
- CERT-In is India's national cyber incident response agency (under MeitY, IT Act Section 70B)
- Report cybercrime via **1930** or **cybercrime.gov.in**
- Key laws: IT Act 2000 (Sections 43, 66, 66C, 66D, 66E, 67), DPDP Act 2023

Key Takeaways

1. Cyber security is everyone's responsibility, not just an IT department's job
2. Most cyberattacks in India succeed through psychological manipulation, not technical hacking
3. No government agency ever demands money or "verification" over a phone/video call
4. Awareness and quick reporting can prevent or reduce financial loss significantly
5. Simple habits — strong passwords, 2FA, verifying before trusting — prevent the vast majority of attacks

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Glossary

- **Antivirus** — Software that detects and removes malicious programs
- **APK** — Android Package file format; installing APKs from unofficial sources is risky
- **Cyber Hygiene** — Routine safe practices for digital safety
- **DDoS** — Distributed Denial of Service; overwhelming a system with traffic to disrupt it
- **Encryption** — Converting data into unreadable code for protection
- **Firewall** — A barrier that filters unauthorised network traffic
- **Identity Theft** — Fraudulent use of someone's personal identity
- **Malware** — Malicious software designed to harm or exploit systems
- **OTP** — One-Time Password
- **Phishing** — Fraud via fake emails/websites to steal information
- **Ransomware** — Malware that locks data and demands payment
- **Smishing** — Phishing via SMS
- **Social Engineering** — Psychological manipulation to bypass security
- **Spyware** — Software that secretly monitors user activity
- **Trojan** — Malware disguised as legitimate software
- **Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)** — An additional identity-verification step
- **Vishing** — Phishing via voice calls
- **VPN** — Virtual Private Network; secures internet connections
- **Vulnerability** — A weakness that can be exploited by a threat
- **Zero-Day** — An unpatched, unknown security flaw

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is cyber security in simple words?
It is the practice of protecting your devices, data, and online identity from digital threats and unauthorised access.

2. Is cyber security only important for computer experts?
No. It is essential for every internet and smartphone user, regardless of technical background.

3. What should I do immediately if I lose money to a cyber fraud?
Call the 1930 helpline immediately and file a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in — speed matters for fund recovery.

4. What is a "digital arrest" scam?
A fraud where scammers impersonate police/officials over video call and pressure victims into transferring money by falsely claiming they are under investigation. It is always fake.

5. Can the police really arrest someone through a video call?
No. Indian law enforcement never conducts arrests, investigations, or fine collection via video/phone call.

6. What is phishing?
A scam that tricks users into revealing sensitive information through fake emails, messages, or websites.

7. Is it safe to share my OTP with a bank employee?
No. Banks never ask customers for OTP, PIN, or CVV under any circumstance.

8. What is the difference between a virus and a worm?
A virus needs a host file to spread, while a worm spreads independently across networks.

9. What is ransomware?
Malware that locks or encrypts your files and demands payment to restore access.

10. How can I recognise a fake website?
Check the URL spelling carefully, look for HTTPS, and avoid sites reached through unsolicited links.

11. Is public Wi-Fi safe for banking?
No. Public Wi-Fi networks are vulnerable to interception; avoid banking transactions on them.

12. What is Two-Factor Authentication?
An extra security step beyond a password, such as an OTP, that verifies your identity during login.

13. Should I click links sent by unknown numbers on WhatsApp?
No. Avoid clicking unknown links, and never install APK files shared this way.

14. What is CERT-In?
India's national agency under MeitY responsible for cyber incident response, alerts, and advisories.

15. Which law in India punishes identity theft?
Section 66C of the Information Technology Act, 2000.

16. What is the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023?
India's comprehensive data protection law giving citizens rights over their personal data, with rules being rolled out in phases starting November 2025.

17. How do I report cyberbullying against a child?
Report on the platform directly, inform a trusted adult, and file a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in, which has special provisions for crimes against children.

18. What is social engineering?
Manipulating people psychologically (through fear, trust, or urgency) to bypass security rather than hacking technology directly.

19. Are deepfake voice scams real?
Yes. Fraudsters increasingly use AI-generated voice clones of relatives or officials to create panic and demand urgent money transfers.

20. What is the single most important cyber safety habit?
Never share OTP, PIN, CVV, or passwords with anyone — this one habit prevents the majority of financial frauds.

21. Where can I check official cybersecurity advisories?
On the CERT-In website (cert-in.org.in) and MeitY's official channels.

22. What happens after I file a complaint on cybercrime.gov.in?
It is forwarded to the relevant State/UT law enforcement agency for investigation and possible conversion into an FIR.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **CIA Triad diagram** → after "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Flowchart: "Anatomy of a Cyber Fraud"** → after "Step-by-Step Understanding"
- **Icon-based threat gallery** (malware, phishing, ransomware icons) → within "Types of Cyber Threats"
- **India cybercrime statistics infographic (bar chart 2024 vs 2025)** → within "Important Statistics"
- **"1930 Helpline" emergency callout card** → placed prominently near Practical Checklist
- **Do's and Don'ts visual card** → after the Do's and Don'ts table

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Official References

- Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) — CERT-In organisational information and mandate
- Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) official RFC 2350 document
- Press Information Bureau (PIB), Government of India — releases on CERT-In, I4C, and cybercrime statistics
- Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) / Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) — cybercrime data (2024–2025)
- Information Technology Act, 2000 (as amended), India Code portal
- Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025
- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal official information pages

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Official Government Website Links

- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: **https://cybercrime.gov.in**
- CERT-In: **https://www.cert-in.org.in**
- Ministry of Electronics & IT (MeitY): **https://www.meity.gov.in**
- Ministry of Home Affairs: **https://www.mha.gov.in**
- Reserve Bank of India: **https://www.rbi.org.in**
- UIDAI (Aadhaar): **https://uidai.gov.in**
- Press Information Bureau: **https://pib.gov.in**
- Digital India: **https://www.digitalindia.gov.in**

Cybercrime Helpline (24×7, Toll-Free): 1930

Conclusion

Cyber security is not about fear — it is about awareness. The vast majority of cyberattacks in India today do not rely on advanced hacking skills; they rely on a moment of panic, trust, or distraction from an ordinary citizen. By understanding what cyber security means, recognising the common types of threats, and knowing exactly where to turn for help, you have already taken the most important step toward protecting yourself, your family, and your community.

This is only the beginning of your Cyber Safety journey with JanGyan. Stay alert, stay informed, and remember: **when in doubt, don't click, don't share, don't pay — verify first.**

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